

The Age of Empowerment

1914-1960

Women's contributions to the war efforts of the 20th century helped to transform their role. The absence of men forced many women into the workplace, making armaments, producing food, and upholding the homefront, while other women took to the battlefields as nurses and soldiers. Women joined forces not only in national efforts, but also in the fight for their own rights. In the first wave of feminism, women mobilized to change unequal laws and to gain the right to vote. Resistance to colonial and oppressive powers also saw women in the developing world unite in protest. By the 1960s, with a new, second wave of feminism just beginning, women were on the brink of a period of great change.